difficult men with whom I have ever had to deal," he "was so important to India and India's survival to all of us" that the US had little choice.[297]

In congressional testimony in support of aid to India that summer, Dulles also echoed his predecessor, identifying Japan and India as the "keystones" of security in Asia. He noted that in both countries the most urgent problem was economic rather than military. Former ambassador Bowles talked of "competitive co-existence," with Stassen highlighting the beginning of Soviet "economic warfare."[298] A foreign aid official elaborated to a key House subcommittee, "With Russia intensifying its efforts to get a foothold in India … and with China developing the show window," it did set up a "competition" and made "the task of India and ourselves perhaps, as hard during the coming year as it has been so far." When Rep. Judd raised concerns about aiding a "socialize[d]" India, the official suggested that, like Asian countries, the US should focus on the contrast between China and India rather than between the more similar American and Indian systems. Judd grudgingly acknowledged, "It is the philosophy of the lesser evil."[299]

Escalating India-Soviet interaction in 1955 only heightened US anxiety. So did intelligence assessments in early 1956 that indicated that China's power and prestige had grown in Asia and that with Soviet assistance, Beijing's military programs were charging ahead.[300] Soviet efforts changed what Dulles called "the scene of the battle" in a way that would eventually come to benefit India.[301]

The tone in India had also changed. US assessments in the second half of 1955 indicated that there was a greater appreciation of American aid in India. There were also suggestions of cooperation in countries like Nepal to counter Chinese influence.[302] Nehru worked to limit public censure of the US, for example, by trying to restrict any official criticism of the Baghdad Pact to private channels.[303] His efforts at message discipline hit a bump in the road with the Dulles statement on Goa. Nehru told senior officials of his concern that, without damage control, the negative reaction in the country would escalate, adversely affecting India-US relations and "indirectly … the question of our receiving any help from the US for our developmental programme." He lamented to Pandit, "Everything that the US might have done to India is likely to be forgotten in the anger caused by this."[304]

For the Indian government, improved India-Soviet and Sino-Indian relationships only made it more important to maintain India's relationship